

Policy Briefing Summary

Board of Supervisors



Regarding: Police Update

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Date Prepared: February 20, 2024

Date of Proposed Action: February 21, 2024

ACTION FORCING EVENT

Our current number of officers cannot adequately and safely support 24/7 coverage over the long-term. Our officers have been working excessive overtime to cover all shifts and are often working alone. Additionally, our Police Chief and Detective have covered many shifts. The 2024 budget does not add additional personnel to the Police Department to address this concern.

BACKGROUND

There are currently 11 officers which includes 9 patrol officers, a Detective, and the Chief. At a public meeting in October of 2023, Chief Matthew Gordon made a strategy presentation and requested growth of the Police Department to a total staffing of 15 officers over multiple years. This includes 12 patrol officers, a Detective, a School Resource Officer, and the Chief. Amy Heinrich, who was the Finance/HR Director, also presented the forecasted costs of the Police Department for the next five years. The 2024 Police Department budget is \$2.4M. The 2027 cost of more staff would be about \$900K higher to \$3.3M per year. This equates to an average of about \$850 per household for the Police Department, which is approximately a \$240 increase per household vs. 2024. After 2027, we would expect increases of approximately \$44 per household per year. These numbers do not include any major building changes, which would likely be necessary with an increase in the size of the Police Department. We will do a strategic analysis of our Township building and related options in 2024.

After careful consideration and feedback from the public, the Board chose not to fund these increases in the 2024 budget and to continue to evaluate options for the future of the Police force. In 2024, it became evident that the current staffing and patrol situation is not a safe long-term option for our officers. Thus, a change is warranted.

ANALYSIS

The October 2023 presentation included review of excessive consecutive shifts and solo shifts, and that the Chief of Police and Detective were often filling patrol shifts. This situation has only worsened, leading to overworked and exhausted officers and the potential for safety risks. We also have had two officers out of work for injuries.

The Board has evaluated the options. The Township is not prepared to take on the additional costs associated with further hiring nor do we have the physical space for a larger police force.

We have considered our regional options, but do not believe that there would be cost savings associated with Regionalization, and that it would take a long time to implement. Given our force and nearby forces are

all unionized, the process to merge unions is not only lengthy and difficult but costly. We would lose some local control, impact the morale of our officers, have high one-time costs associated with disbanding our union, and most importantly would not be likely to see substantial annual cost savings. Regional options are only an option in the more distant future and would offer no near-term relief for costs or for our officers.

Many surrounding municipalities in southern Chester County are still utilizing State Police either full-time or for the overnight hours. We have spoken with the Lieutenant from the Avondale State Police barracks. They can provide overnight coverage from midnight to 6 am, effective in very short order. Their target staffing level overnight is three cars of two patrol officers each and a car with a supervisor. While they do have a large region to cover, their call volume is also lowest overnight. They believe that they can provide an acceptable service level to our residents between midnight and 6 am. The State Police have committed to providing detailed reporting on level and type of activity and response time so the Township can monitor the situation closely. Coverage can be implemented quickly, and it can also be terminated quickly should we feel that the Township needs are served better in another way.

State coverage overnight will enable our current force to service the Township effectively and safely from 6 am until midnight, which is when approximately 92.5% of our 911 calls for police service occur. We would also keep the current level of staffing. The Township would not eliminate any positions. There would be two 12-hour shifts (6 am to 6pm and noon to midnight) with two people scheduled to each shift. This will enable our Chief and Detective to serve in their respective roles, rather than filling shifts. There will be shift overlap from noon to 6 pm, which are our busiest hours. We can also shift officers or utilize more reasonable overtime to fill openings from 6 am to noon and 6pm to midnight when scheduled officers are on paid time off. Lastly, it may enable our Police Department to provide more specialized services if it is determined that State Police coverage is a long-term solution.

The overnight hours from midnight to 6 am are our least busy time. We average just over one 911 call every other night for the police. About half of those calls are for assistance to other agencies, primarily Ambulance and Fire. See exhibits for overnight 911 call information for 2022 and 2023. Our officers also provide important proactive policing services and patrolling which are not included in these numbers. We acknowledge that moving to State coverage is not ideal and becomes a cost vs. risk trade-off.

We are sensitive to the community's needs and concerns, while also keeping public safety in mind. We have listened to the public's concern over rising taxes along with questioning the need for Township provided 24/7 police coverage by the Kennett Township Police Department. Most importantly, we need to act now to ensure officer safety. Our staff will monitor the situation closely and provide updates to the Board of Supervisors and the public. Finally, we want to hear from the public about any impact of this change.

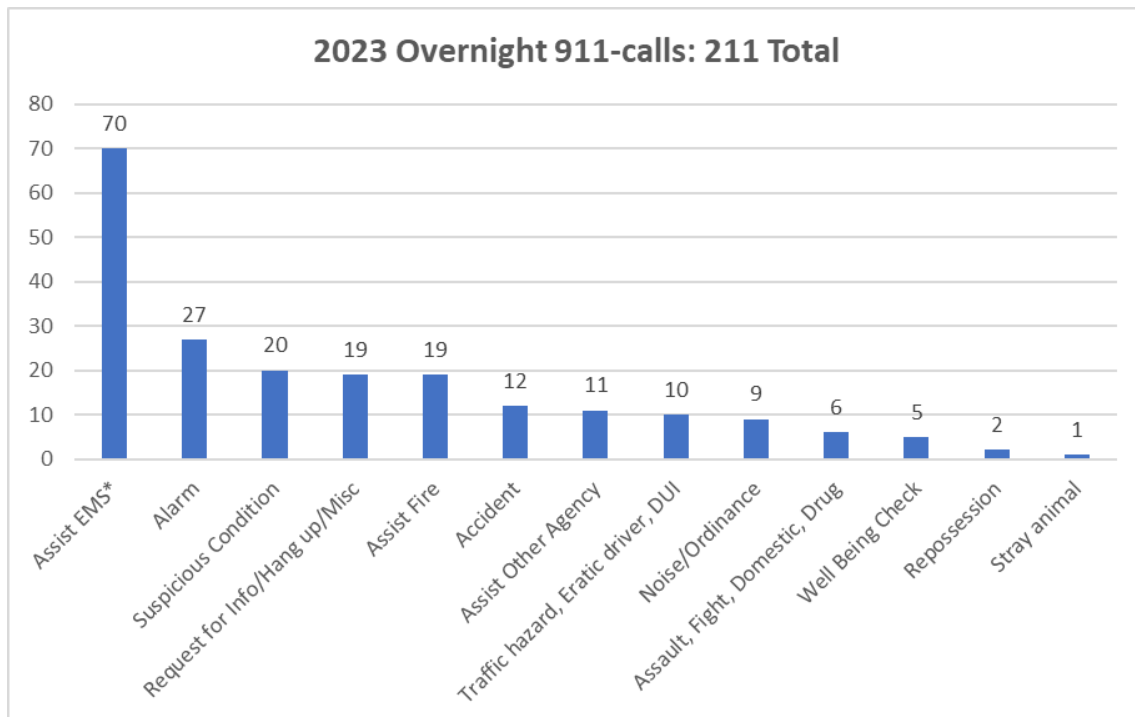
FINANCIAL IMPACT

The Pennsylvania State Police are required to provide coverage to any municipality in Pennsylvania at no additional cost to the Township or the taxpayers. Therefore, there is no financial increase to utilizing the State Police. We are likely to save money on overtime although the budget was already reduced vs. 2023.

MOTION FOR CONSIDATION

Motion to utilize Pennsylvania State Police coverage for Kennett Township from midnight to 6 am effective March 1, 2024.

2023 Overnight 911-calls				
Description	Count	Percent of Total	% of 365 Nights	Every X nights
Assist EMS*	70	33%	19%	5.2
Alarm	27	13%	7%	13.5
Suspicious Condition	20	9%	5%	18.3
Request for Info/Hang up/Misc	19	9%	5%	19.2
Assist Fire	19	9%	5%	19.2
Accident	12	6%	3%	30.4
Assist Other Agency	11	5%	3%	33.2
Traffic hazard, Eratic driver, DUI	10	5%	3%	36.5
Noise/Ordinance	9	4%	2%	40.6
Assault, Fight, Domestic, Drug	6	3%	2%	60.8
Well Being Check	5	2%	1%	73.0
Repossession	2	1%	1%	182.5
Stray animal	1	0%	0%	365.0
Grand Total**	211		58%	1.7
Total with onsite response	171			2.1
Includes all Calls in CODY that began between Midnight and 5:59 am.				
*22 of which didn't require an onsite response from Kennett Police				
**40 of which didn't require an onsite response. Additionally, 19 of which were during the Calvacante escape.				



2022 Overnight 911-calls				
Row Labels	Count	Percent of Total	% of 365 Nights	Every X nights
Assist EMS*	72	35%	20%	5.1
Alarm	30	15%	8%	12.2
Request for Info/Hang up/Misc	19	9%	5%	19.2
Traffic hazard, Eratic driver, DUI	13	6%	4%	28.1
Accident	12	6%	3%	30.4
Assist Fire	12	6%	3%	30.4
Assist Other Agency	9	4%	2%	40.6
Noise/Ordinance	8	4%	2%	45.6
Assault, Fight, Domestic, PFA Violation, Drug	6	3%	2%	60.8
Suspicious Condition	6	3%	2%	60.8
Well Being Check	5	2%	1%	73.0
Death - non-criminal or overdose	4	2%	1%	91.3
Stray animal	2	1%	1%	182.5
Emotional Disorder	2	1%	1%	182.5
Keys, Lockout	2	1%	1%	182.5
Missing person	1	0%	0%	365.0
Repossession	1	0%	0%	365.0
Grand Total**	204		56%	1.8
Total with onsite response	173			2.1
Includes all Calls in CODY that began between Midnight and 5:59 am.				
*19 of which Kennett Police were told not necessary to respond				
**31 of which didn't require an onsite response				

